



Cover story

GUARDING THE Megacity

Build a security fortress around Delhi and Mumbai so that they are capable of tackling any kind of emergency independently



India lives with a certain fatalism today, one born out of the truth left lingering after the Mumbai attack: that if it can happen to Mumbai, then everyone is vulnerable. Mumbai and New Delhi are prized terror targets because of what they stand for—Delhi for power, Mumbai for wealth. India needs to demonstrate that it can protect these two cities, or it will convince few—least of all its enemies—that it has the will to safeguard its democracy.

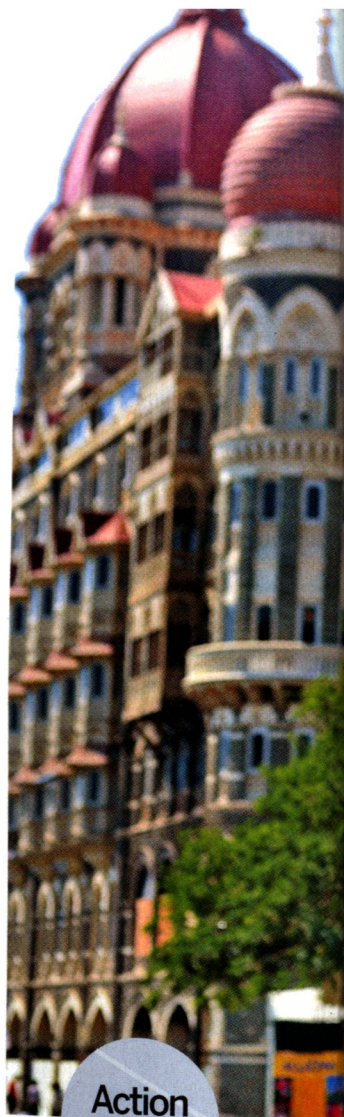
The challenges of securing the twin megacities are multiplied by geography and demographics. Both cities cover large areas, with a heavy press of population that is watched by an undermanned and demotivated police force. The police force's proximity to the political establishment is widely recognised as a corrupting influence which has had its impact on the performance and the public perception of the force.

Yet, acceptance of this status quo is not an option any longer. Our megacities have to become virtual fortresses against men like the terrorists of November 26. These fortresses must be constructed with human intelligence and coordination, backed by the best of weapons, surveillance technology and investigation equipment.

Detecting, pre-empting and responding to terror can only happen after the task is specifically compartmentalised and detached from other aspects of policing. There is an urgent need to create a state-level fighting force comprising armed police, trained and reserved only to tackle combat situations. Setting up a team of even 100 men is estimated to take at least six months.

The city police's investigation machinery must be separated from the ranks of general law and order maintenance. The setting up of a centralised command centre and a specific chain of command in a terror attack is of prime importance. These control rooms need to be able to integrate seamlessly with the city's intelligent traffic management network. The 26/11 attacks also demonstrated the damage caused by lack of intelligence integration. The police needs to work in greater coordination with departments like Income Tax, Customs and intelligence. The link between organised crime, money-laundering and terrorism has been all too clearly established. Merely protecting "turf" in these matters is a dereliction of their national duty.

The immediate identification of the 50 most vulnerable



Action Plan

CREATE a city-level force comprising armed police, trained and reserved only for combat situations.

IDENTIFY and move to protect the most vulnerable spots in a city.

ESTABLISH a centralised control room to monitor suspicious activity.

STRENGTHEN the informer network, coordinate with intelligence, customs and tax agencies.